INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #7 · PARENTING

“If my child struggles, it's my fault.”

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Where it often comes from

Parents often feel responsible for everything that happens to their children. When a child struggles with anxiety, school, friends, behavior, or faith, we search our own parenting for the cause. Well-meaning advice and a misreading of verses about training children can add to the weight.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says, “A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son.” “Each of us will give an account of himself to God.” Children are individuals with their own will, temperament, and choices. Proverbs says, “Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it.” That is a general principle of wise living, not a guarantee, and not a measure of a parent’s worth. The father in Jesus’ story of the prodigal son did nothing wrong, and yet his son left. When his son came back, “his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him.”

> *“The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him”* (Ezekiel 18:20).

Also see

> “So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God” (Romans 14:12).

> “Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it” (Proverbs 22:6).

> “So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him” (Luke 15:20).

> “As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him” (Psalm 103:13).

Common self-statements

- I must have caused this.
- If I had been a better parent, they would not struggle.
- It is all because of what I did.
- I should have seen this coming.
- Other parents’ kids are fine.
- It is my job to fix everything.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Taking responsibility for things beyond my control.
- Hindsight bias: Judging past choices by what I know now.
- Mind reading: Assuming my child blames me.
- Magical thinking: Believing good parenting guarantees a good outcome.

Challenging questions

- What factors beyond me contribute, such as temperament, friends, biology, or choices?
- Has my child made decisions that are their own?
- What real mistakes, if any, can I own without taking all the blame?
- What does the father in the prodigal son story teach me?
- What does my child need from me now?
- What can I trust God with?

Truth summary

> I influence my children, but I do not control them. Some of what they face is not my fault, and some may be mine to own and repair. I can love them, take responsibility for what is mine, and trust God with the rest.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Children
- Guilt/Shame
- Trust
- Adolescent Guidance

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Our God — Chris Tomlin
God's greatness challenges helplessness before evil or hardship.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If my child struggles, it's my fault"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If my child struggles, it's my fault." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What factors beyond me are involved?
- ☐ What is mine to own?
- ☐ What can I release?
- ☐ What does my child need now?
- ☐ What can I apologize for?
- ☐ How can I pray?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My child is responsible for their own choices.
- ☐ I am not the cause of everything.
- ☐ I can own real mistakes and repair them.
- ☐ A loving father runs to meet a returning child.
- ☐ God cares for my child more than I do.
- ☐ I can trust God with what I cannot control.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ezekiel 18:20
  "The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him."
- ☐ Luke 15:20
  "So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him."
- ☐ Romans 14:12
  "So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Mine and not mine: Each week, write one thing that is mine to do and one thing you will release to God.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 14:12 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Each person answers to God, so I do not carry what is not mine.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Parenting" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Make two columns. List what is yours to own and what is not.
- [ ] Own what is true. If there is a real mistake, apologize without excuses or self-punishment.
- [ ] Be present. Spend one-on-one time with your child without fixing.
- [ ] Pray for your child. Pray by name, entrusting them to God each day.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If my child struggles, it's my fault": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Released to God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If my child struggles, it's my fault.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I carry my child's struggles as my own guilt. Show me what is mine to own and what is not. Help me love them well and trust them to You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.